



pretty close to a second Partition in the 1980s, but managed to avoid it after much bloodshed on both sides. The North-East and Kashmir still remain volatile, and one never knows what the future holds for them. On the whole, however, we have remained a united country and, with some exceptions, a united people. How did this happen?

Democracy has certainly helped. Although it sometimes encourages fissiparous tendencies, it has been open enough to include new groups, empower them and give them a hope. Without the legitimacy that it has given to our political institutions, many Indians would have had no stake in the country, and could easily have been tempted to resort to acts of violence and disorder.

Even more important than democracy is our

contributions of the Hindu culture, itself a composite product of classical Hindu, Buddhist, Jain and other influences, as well as those of Islam, Christianity and secular modernity. These interacting strands of thought, sometimes in tension and sometimes in harmony, have created over time a highly complex framework within which different groups of Indians lead their lives.

Most Indians, be they Hindus, Muslims, or Christians, can hardly speak for five minutes without resorting to their Sanskrit-derived local language, Urdu and bits of English. Their mode of thinking and the structure of their identity are also multi-conceptual. They draw on Hindu heritage in some areas of life such



MYSTICAL BOND: The foundation stone of the Golden Temple being laid by Miyan Mir, a Muslim composite culture, which sustains and gives it its energy and openness. Indeed I cannot think of any country, new or old, that can match India's achievement in this field. The composite culture is evident in its cuisine, language, music, dress, literature and the arts. They are all creative products of the centuries-long interaction between the different cultures that came to our land. Every Indian language has at least a third of its vocabulary drawn from Persian, Arabic, or Turkish. Our dresses, including the sari, are a composite product, and so are our traditional musical instruments and ragas. All our great minds have been raised on the milk of many cultures. Rabindranath Tagore, on his own testimony, is a product of the classical Hindu, Muslim, Christian and secular influences. Gandhi is so unclassifiable that it is difficult to isolate the Buddhist, the Hindu, the Jain, the Christian, the Judaic and the secular-liberal elements of his thought.

The composite culture of India has a highly complex identity. It is not unitary and homogeneous, but plural, and contains within it a large range of inassimilable diversity. Yet this diversity is not chaotic and has a recognisable structure and language of expression. It includes the

After Partition, India remained what it had always been, a multi-religious and multicultural country. Indian Muslims do not represent the unfinished agenda of Partition.

as moral and social relations; Muslim heritage in music and romantic love; their secular and western heritage when dealing with civil, economic and political matters; and their Christian heritage in matters involving social service, concern for the poor and non-violence. Sometimes they even draw on all of these heritages, as in architecture and the interior décor of their house.

Our composite culture is our collective asset. It has no single source or owner, and that is its strength. All Indians see something of themselves in it, some no doubt more than others, and feel uninhibited in embracing it. This is not to say that there are no tensions. Some Hindus feel uneasy about Islamic and Christian elements, just as some Muslims feel this way about Hindu elements. What matters is the different communities have enough in common to communicate with each other and take pride in it.

The influence of the composite culture in shaping our religious, regional and ethnic consciousness should not be underestimated. The Indian Muslim views his religion differently from the way his Saudi Arabian or Pakistani counterpart does. He values it, thinks it the best, yet he is generally not only tolerant but respectful of others. As many commentators have observed, among the Muslim migrants to Europe those

